

An Articles Section

A footer-linked library of devotional & theological articles that turns topic searches into readers of the classics — the model, the topics answer, the SEO anatomy, the first ten articles, and how to roll it out.

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What this is, in one paragraph

Nobody searches for a public-domain book by name. They search for *problems and questions* — “how to trust God,” “what does it mean to abide in Christ.” Articles are the bridge: 1,500–2,000-word evergreen pages that answer those queries and, at the end, hand the reader the exact book, sermon, or biography that goes deeper. They rank on their own and they pass authority down to the library pages, which have thin search demand today. English first; the per-language model makes translation free later.

THE TWO DECISIONS THIS BRIEF SETTLES

Articles carry **no author or byline** — they are simply great pages on the site, not works attributed to anyone. And topics are handled in **two layers**: articles **reuse the shared Topic taxonomy** for cross-linking with books and sermons, *and* get their own **Series/cluster model** for SEO structure. Both, not either.

The data model

Mirror the shapes the codebase already uses. Nothing here is novel — an Article is a Book-shaped row without an author.

FIELD	WHAT IT HOLDS & WHY
slug + language	unique(slug, language), exactly like Books and Sermons. One English row today; a translation is later just a new row on the same slug. There is no author FK .
title, h1	The SEO <title> and the on-page <h1> kept as separate fields — the title tag leads with the keyword, the H1 can be warmer.
dek / meta_description	The 150-char answer-first summary, used as the meta description and the lede.
body	The article HTML/markdown: intro + H2 sections + inline pull-quotes drawn from the classic authors (reuse the quote infrastructure).
topics (M2M)	Links to the existing Topic rows — the shared cross-content graph. (Next page.)
series + order	FK to a new ArticleSeries for the SEO cluster, plus a position within it. (Next page.)
related (natural keys)	The funnel: a list of book / sermon / author slugs the “Read next” block renders. This is the whole point of the section.
status, published_at	draft / published, so a half-written article never ships. og_image optional (reuse a cover, or a generated card).

THREE THINGS TO GET RIGHT

- ☐ **Prerender, do not SPA.** Articles must live in the prerendered SEO tier, not the client app — real <title>, meta, canonical, Open Graph and Article JSON-LD in the source. This is the entire reason the section exists; an SPA article is invisible to crawlers.
- ☐ **Footer, not header.** A single “Articles” link in the footer to /articles; individual pages at /articles/<slug>. Add every article to the sitemap.
- ☐ **Seed as create-only where a workflow owns a field.** Same rule as the rest of the library: if an editor hand-edits status or body after creation, the seed must not revert it on the next deploy.

ONE HONEST NOTE

Because articles have no author and are new writing (not public-domain text), never let one **quote a classic at length** in a way that reads as the author’s own page — keep pull-quotes short and attributed, and let the “Read next” link carry the reader to the real work.

Topics: two layers, two jobs

The question was “their own model *and* reuse the Topics taxonomy — does that work?” Yes, and it is the right call, because these are two different problems.

Layer 1 · Reuse Topic (shared)

Tag each article with existing **Topic** rows — Prayer, Faith, Grace. Many-to-many. This is the **cross-content graph**: the article appears on the shared topic page next to books and sermons, and a book page can surface “Articles about Prayer.” The funnel becomes bidirectional.

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Layer 2 · ArticleSeries (article-only)

A new model for the **SEO cluster**: a pillar article plus its supporting pieces, ordered, with its own landing page at `/articles/<series>`. This is publishing structure — it must not leak into the shared taxonomy that books and sermons also use.

Rule of thumb: **Topic** answers “what is this about?” (shared vocabulary). **Series** answers “which SEO cluster does this belong to, and in what order?” (articles only).

WHY NOT FORCE ONE TO DO BOTH

If you only reused **Topic**, you’d have no clean way to say “this is the pillar, these three support it, render them in this order” without overloading a taxonomy that Books and Sermons also depend on. If you only had a **Series**, articles would be islands — invisible on the topic pages that already gather the whole library. Each layer does the job the other cannot.

WORKED EXAMPLE — THE PRAYER CLUSTER

Series: Learning to Pray (pillar + 4)

Topic: Prayer

Topic: Faith

The pillar “Spiritual Disciplines Every Christian Should Know” sits in the **Learning to Pray** series and links down to its four supporting articles (Müller, Bounds, Brother Lawrence, unanswered prayer). Every one of those five is **also** tagged **Topic: Prayer**, so they surface on the site-wide Prayer topic page beside *Life of Trust, Power Through Prayer*, and the prayer sermons — and each book page can now show “Articles about Prayer” in return.

NET EFFECT

Series builds the tight internal-link cluster Google rewards; Topic wires that cluster into the library you already have. The reader lands from search, reads the article, and is one click from the actual classic.

The anatomy of one article

Same skeleton every time — it helps readers, featured snippets, and the writer.

PART	WHAT IT DOES
H1 (warm)	One per page, keyword-bearing but human. Distinct from the <title> tag, which leads with the keyword + “Ochorus.”
Answer-first intro	2-3 sentences that answer the query immediately — this is what wins the featured snippet.
4-6 H2 sections	One idea each, ~250-350 words, with a short attributed pull-quote from the classic author woven in.
“Read next” block	The funnel. Links to the anchor book + bio + sermon from related. Converts the reader and passes authority to library pages.
Head tags	meta description, canonical, OG/Twitter, and Article JSON-LD — all in the prerendered source.

LENGTH & CADENCE

1,500-2,000 words is right — long enough to rank and to genuinely help, short enough to finish. Publish in **clusters**, **not singletons**: a pillar plus its supporting pieces shipped together links internally from day one, which is what search rewards. Aim for one cluster of 4-6 every couple of weeks rather than scattered one-offs.

MEASURING WHETHER IT WORKS

- ☐ Impressions & average position per article in Search Console (are the H1/title keywords ranking?).
- ☐ Click-through from the “Read next” block into books/sermons/bios — the true conversion.
- ☐ Which library pages gain traffic *because* an article links to them (the authority pass-down).

ANCHOR TO CONTENT YOU ALREADY HAVE

Start every article on an author whose work is already in the library, so the “Read next” link is genuinely the best next step. Write toward the library, not away from it.

The first ten articles

Highest search volume × strongest existing anchor, front-loading prayer, faith and trust. Each H1 is the on-page headline; the SEO title tag leads with the keyword and appends “— Ochorus.”

#	H1	SUBJECT	READ NEXT → & SERIES
1	How to Pray So That God Answers: Lessons from George Müller	Answered prayer · George Müller	Life of Trust · Müller bio Learning to Pray
2	What It Means to Abide in Christ (And How to Actually Do It)	Abiding in Christ · Andrew Murray	Abide in Christ · Murray bio Union with Christ
3	The Secret to a Happy Christian Life	The happy Christian life · Hannah Whitall Smith	The Christian's Secret... · Smith bio The Deeper Life
4	How to Practice the Presence of God in Ordinary Days	Presence of God · Brother Lawrence	Practice of the Presence · bio Learning to Pray
5	What Is Faith? A Plain, Biblical Answer	Defining faith	Life of Trust · Christian's Secret The Deeper Life
6	How to Trust God When Your Life Is Falling Apart	Trusting God in hardship	Christian's Secret · Life of Trust The Deeper Life
7	Why Humility Is the Root of Every Other Virtue	Humility · Andrew Murray & Bernard	Humility · On Loving God Christlike Character
8	What Is Grace? The Gift You Can't Earn and Can't Lose	Grace · Charles Spurgeon	All of Grace · Spurgeon bio Grace & Salvation
9	When God Seems Silent: How to Wait on Unanswered Prayer	Unanswered prayer · waiting	Power Through Prayer · Life of Trust Learning to Pray
10	How to Read the Bible Devotionally — Not Just Study It	Devotional Bible reading	Imitation of Christ · Abide in Christ Christlike Character

Series in play: [Learning to Pray](#) (1, 4, 9 + a pillar), [The Deeper Life](#) (3, 5, 6), [Union with Christ](#) (2), [Christlike Character](#) (7, 10), [Grace & Salvation](#) (8). Ship the three Learning-to-Pray pieces plus a “Spiritual Disciplines” pillar as the first complete cluster.

Rollout

One PR per slice, off origin/main, in a worktree — the standing workflow.

1. **Model + admin.** Article (slug+language, title, h1, dek, body, related, status), ArticleSeries, and the M2M to the existing Topic. Fixture is one file per article, natural keys, create-only where a workflow owns the field.
2. **Prerendered routes.** /articles index, /articles/<slug>, and /articles/<series> landing pages — generate entries() from the API, like the book/author prerender. Add meta, OG, canonical and Article JSON-LD to the head; add all three to the sitemap.
3. **Footer link + funnel block.** One “Articles” link in the footer (not the header). Build the reusable “Read next” component from related, and add “Articles about X” to the topic and book pages so the graph is bidirectional.
4. **First cluster.** Write the Learning-to-Pray cluster (Müller, Brother Lawrence, unanswered prayer) plus its pillar, all anchored to books already in the library. Ship together so they link internally on day one.
5. **Measure, then scale.** Wire Search Console, watch impressions and the click-through into the library, and let the winners tell you which of the twenty clusters to write next. Translate only after the English cluster proves itself.

THE TWENTY IDEAS THIS BUILDS TOWARD

Beyond the first ten: contemplative prayer (Guyon), the Imitation of Christ (à Kempis), sanctification, hearing God’s voice, prayerlessness & power (Bounds), overcoming anxiety, Pilgrim’s Progress (Bunyan), On Loving God (Bernard), and an African-voices piece on Samuel Crowther that seeds that cluster early. Each maps to a work already in — or already on the roadmap for — the library.

THE ONE MEASURE OF SUCCESS

An article earns its place when a reader arrives from a Google search they typed as a *question*, and leaves having opened the classic that answers it. Everything above serves that single motion.